

THE GOSPEL ACCORDING TO JOHN

John 3

The New Birth, God's Love, and the Supremacy of Christ

Purpose of This Study

To understand why every person must be born from above, how God's saving love is revealed in His Son, and why genuine discipleship gladly gives Jesus the highest place.

Key Verse

"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life." - John 3:16 (ESV)

Big Idea

Religious knowledge and human effort cannot produce spiritual life. God gives new birth by His Spirit and eternal life through faith in His Son, who must increase above all.

Chapter Outline

- John 3:1-21 - Jesus teaches Nicodemus about the new birth and saving faith.
- John 3:22-30 - John the Baptist rejoices that Jesus is increasing.
- John 3:31-36 - The Son from above has supreme authority and gives eternal life.

Context

John 2 ends by saying that Jesus knows what is in every person. John 3 immediately introduces Nicodemus, a respected religious leader whose heart and deepest need are known by Jesus. The chapter contrasts earthly religion with heavenly life, darkness with light, and human prominence with the supremacy of Christ.

John 3:1-3 - Nicodemus Comes to Jesus at Night

Read: Nicodemus is a Pharisee and ruler of the Jews. He approaches Jesus at night and acknowledges that His signs show God is with Him. Jesus answers that no one can see God's kingdom without being born again - or born from above.

Observation - What does the text say?

Nicodemus has religious education, status, morality, and respect. Yet Jesus does not congratulate his accomplishments; He identifies a need that Nicodemus cannot meet for himself.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

The expression can mean both 'again' and 'from above.' Entrance into God's kingdom requires a new origin and new life from God. Religion can reform behavior, but it cannot create spiritual life.

Application - How should we respond?

Do not rely on church background, knowledge, position, or good works. Ask whether God has given you new life through faith in Christ.

Scripture support

- Ezekiel 36:25-27 - God promises cleansing, a new heart, and His Spirit.
- 2 Corinthians 5:17 - Anyone in Christ is a new creation.
- Titus 3:5 - Salvation comes through regeneration and renewal by the Holy Spirit.

John 3:4-8 - Born of Water and the Spirit

Read: Nicodemus misunderstands Jesus as speaking of a second physical birth. Jesus explains that one must be born of water and the Spirit. Flesh produces flesh; the Spirit produces spirit. The Spirit's work is sovereign like the wind.

Observation - What does the text say?

Jesus contrasts natural birth with spiritual birth. The wind is unseen, but its effects are evident. In the same way, the Spirit's regenerating work is mysterious yet produces observable change.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

'Water and Spirit' echoes Ezekiel 36, where cleansing and the gift of the Spirit belong to one saving work of God. Jesus is not describing human self-improvement but divine cleansing and renewal.

Application - How should we respond?

Depend on the Holy Spirit rather than attempting to manufacture spiritual life. Look for the fruit of His transforming work, not merely an outward religious label.

Scripture support

- Ezekiel 36:25-27 - Water and Spirit describe cleansing and renewal.
- John 1:12-13 - God's children are born of God.
- Galatians 5:22-23 - The Spirit's work produces visible fruit.
- 1 Peter 1:23 - Believers are born again through God's living Word.

John 3:9-13 - Jesus Speaks with Heavenly Authority

Read: Nicodemus asks how these things can be. Jesus challenges his failure to understand Scripture and says He testifies to what He knows. No one has ascended into heaven except the Son of Man who

descended from heaven.

Observation - What does the text say?

Nicodemus is called 'the teacher of Israel,' yet he misses truths promised in the prophets. Jesus speaks as an eyewitness of heavenly reality, not as one religious teacher among many.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

Jesus alone is qualified to reveal the Father and heavenly salvation because He came from heaven. His authority rests in His divine origin and firsthand knowledge.

Application - How should we respond?

Submit your understanding to Jesus. Biblical scholarship is valuable, but it must lead to humble faith in the One to whom Scripture points.

Scripture support

- Deuteronomy 30:12 - God's word is not inaccessible in heaven.
- Proverbs 30:4 - The question of who has ascended and descended points to divine wisdom.
- John 1:18 - The Son makes the unseen God known.
- Luke 24:25-27 - Scripture points to Christ.

John 3:14-17 - The Son of Man Must Be Lifted Up

Read: Jesus compares His coming lifting up to Moses lifting up the bronze serpent in the wilderness. Everyone who believes in Him receives eternal life. God loved the world and gave His only Son, not to condemn the world but to save it through Him.

Observation - What does the text say?

The word 'must' shows divine necessity. The cross is not an accident. As dying Israelites looked at God's appointed provision and lived, sinners must look in faith to the crucified Son.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

God's love is demonstrated by costly giving. 'World' emphasizes the undeserving and rebellious human world. The Father's sending and the Son's lifting up accomplish salvation for believers.

Application - How should we respond?

Look away from self-reliance to Christ. Receive eternal life as God's gift, and let His love shape the way you love and proclaim the gospel to others.

Scripture support

- Numbers 21:4-9 - Those who looked at the lifted serpent lived.
- Romans 5:8 - God demonstrates His love through Christ's death.
- Romans 8:32 - The Father did not spare His own Son.
- 1 John 4:9-10 - God's love is revealed in sending His Son.

John 3:18-21 - Light Reveals the Human Response

Read: Whoever believes in the Son is not condemned; whoever rejects Him is condemned already. Light has entered the world, but people love darkness because their deeds are evil. The one who practices truth comes to the light.

Observation - What does the text say?

Jesus divides humanity according to its response to Him. Judgment is not merely future; unbelief leaves a person under present condemnation. Light exposes both deeds and motives.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

The fundamental problem is moral, not merely intellectual: people resist the light because it threatens cherished sin. Genuine faith comes into the light, allowing God's work to be seen.

Application - How should we respond?

Come honestly into Christ's light. Confess rather than hide sin, and measure faith by a growing willingness to live openly before God.

Scripture support

- John 1:4-5,9-11 - The true Light enters a resistant world.
- Psalm 139:23-24 - Invite God to search the heart.
- Ephesians 5:8-14 - Believers are to walk as children of light.
- 1 John 1:5-9 - Walking in the light includes confession and cleansing.

John 3:22-26 - Two Ministries Appear to Overlap

Read: Jesus and His disciples minister in Judea while John is baptizing nearby. A discussion about purification leads John's disciples to report that Jesus is attracting everyone.

Observation - What does the text say?

John's followers view Jesus' growing ministry as competition. Their words reveal anxiety about influence and attention, even though John had already identified Jesus as the Lamb of God.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

Ministry jealousy grows when servants forget that the work belongs to God. The success of Jesus is not a threat to John's mission; it is the fulfillment of it.

Application - How should we respond?

Refuse to treat ministry as personal territory. Rejoice when Christ is honored through someone else's faithful service.

Scripture support

- John 1:29-34 - John publicly identifies Jesus as the Lamb and Son of God.
- 1 Corinthians 3:5-9 - Servants plant and water, but God gives growth.
- Philippians 1:15-18 - Paul rejoices that Christ is proclaimed.

John 3:27-30 - He Must Increase

Read: John answers that a person can receive only what heaven gives. He repeats that he is not the Christ but was sent ahead of Him. Like the friend of the bridegroom, John rejoices at the bridegroom's voice and declares, 'He must increase, but I must decrease.'

Observation - What does the text say?

John understands his assignment, identity, and limits. His joy is complete when people go to Jesus. He does not merely tolerate Christ's increase; he celebrates it.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

Jesus is the bridegroom, the central figure in God's saving purpose. John models true ministry: receive a calling from God, point people to Christ, and gladly step out of the center.

Application - How should we respond?

Evaluate whether your service draws attention to Christ or to yourself. Make John 3:30 a continuing prayer for your teaching, ministry, and daily life.

Scripture support

- Isaiah 62:5 - Bridegroom imagery expresses covenant joy.
- Mark 10:42-45 - Kingdom greatness is expressed through service.
- Galatians 2:20 - The believer's life is centered in Christ.
- 1 Peter 4:10-11 - Serve so that God is glorified through Jesus Christ.

John 3:31-34 - The One from Above Speaks God's Words

Read: The One who comes from above is above all. He testifies to what He has seen and heard, though many reject His testimony. The One sent by God speaks God's words, for God gives the Spirit without measure.

Observation - What does the text say?

Jesus is contrasted with every earthly messenger. His testimony comes from heaven, His words are God's words, and the Spirit rests upon Him without measure.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

The Son's supremacy is based on His heavenly origin and unique relationship with the Father and Spirit. To receive His testimony is to affirm that God is truthful.

Application - How should we respond?

Give Jesus final authority over every opinion, tradition, and personal preference. Receive His testimony as God's own truth.

Scripture support

- Isaiah 11:1-5 - The Spirit rests upon the promised Messiah.
- John 1:32-34 - The Spirit remains on Jesus.
- John 8:26-29 - Jesus speaks what He heard from the Father.
- Hebrews 1:1-3 - God has spoken finally in His Son.

John 3:35-36 - Life or Wrath Depends on the Son

Read: The Father loves the Son and has placed all things into His hand. Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life; whoever rejects the Son will not see life, and God's wrath remains on that person.

Observation - What does the text say?

John ends with a present-tense contrast: the believer has life now, while the rejecter remains under wrath. The response to the Son has eternal consequences.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

The Father's love for the Son and the Son's universal authority make Him the decisive issue for every person. Biblical faith includes trusting and obeying the Son; persistent rejection leaves guilt unresolved.

Application - How should we respond?

Do not postpone your response to Jesus. Trust Him, submit to His authority, and clearly present both God's loving invitation and the seriousness of rejecting His Son.

Scripture support

- Psalm 2:7-12 - God's Son rules, and refuge is found in Him.
- John 5:21-24 - The believer has crossed from death to life.
- Romans 1:18 - God's wrath is revealed against ungodliness.
- 1 John 5:11-12 - Whoever has the Son has life.

Five Major Truths in John 3

1. Everyone Needs the New Birth

Religious knowledge, morality, ancestry, and achievement cannot create spiritual life. New birth is God's cleansing and renewing work through the Holy Spirit.

2. Jesus Alone Reveals Heavenly Truth

The Son came from above and speaks with firsthand divine authority. He is not one teacher among equals.

3. God's Love Is Revealed at the Cross

The Father gave His only Son, and the Son was lifted up so that believers may receive eternal life.

4. Every Person Must Respond to the Light

Faith comes into the light; unbelief prefers darkness and remains under condemnation.

5. Jesus Must Increase

True ministry finds joy in directing people to Christ and giving Him the highest place.

Key Words and Ideas

Term	Meaning in John 3
Born again/from above	A new spiritual origin and life given by God, not a second physical birth or human reform.
Kingdom of God	God's saving rule, entered only through the life-giving work of the Spirit.
Believe	Personal trust in and reliance upon the Son, expressed in receiving His testimony and coming to the light.
Eternal life	God's life received now through Christ and enjoyed forever in fellowship with Him.
Light/darkness	Jesus reveals truth and exposes sin; darkness represents sinful resistance and concealment.
Wrath	God's settled holy judgment against sin, which remains where the Son is rejected.

Personal and Group Application

Use these questions for prayer, journaling, or group discussion.

- What religious credentials or personal efforts might tempt me to rely on something other than new life from God?
- Where am I resisting the Spirit's work or hiding from Christ's light?
- How does the bronze-serpent account clarify what it means to look to Christ in faith?
- Does my life show that Jesus is increasing and self-importance is decreasing?
- How can I communicate both God's love and the seriousness of rejecting the Son?

Discussion Questions

- Why was Nicodemus surprised by the teaching about new birth?
- How does Ezekiel 36 help explain 'water and the Spirit'?
- What does John 3:16 reveal about the source, object, cost, and purpose of God's love?
- Why do people prefer darkness according to Jesus?
- What protected John the Baptist from jealousy?
- How do verses 35-36 complete the chapter's message?

Suggested Teaching Plan (60 Minutes)

Time	Teaching Movement
5 min	Opening, context, and the chapter's big idea.
15 min	John 3:1-8 - Nicodemus and the necessity of new birth.
10 min	John 3:9-13 - Jesus' heavenly authority.
15 min	John 3:14-21 - The lifted Son, God's love, faith, judgment, and light.
8 min	John 3:22-30 - John the Baptist's joyful decrease.
5 min	John 3:31-36 - The supremacy of the Son and the final choice.
2 min	Summary and closing prayer.

Gospel Connection

John 3 presents salvation as God's work and God's gift. The Spirit gives new birth; the Father gives His Son; the Son is lifted up for sinners; and the believer receives eternal life. The gospel calls us out of darkness to trust the crucified and risen Son.

Final Review and Prayer

Before ending the study, review the chapter and identify one response of faith.

What John 3 Reveals About Jesus

- He came from above and speaks God's words with final authority.
- He is the only Son given because God loved the world.
- He had to be lifted up so believers could receive eternal life.
- He is the Light who exposes the true condition of every heart.
- He is above all and must increase.

My Response

One truth about Jesus I need to remember:

One step of faith or obedience I will take:

One person with whom I can share the good news:

Closing Prayer

Father, thank You for loving the world and giving Your Son. Holy Spirit, give understanding and produce the fruit of new life in us. Lord Jesus, bring us into the light, deepen our faith, and increase in every part of our lives. Help us proclaim Your truth with grace and conviction. Amen.

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